The Journal

Soon after the founding of the Guild it became clear to those on the Committee that they needed to keep in touch with woodturners around the country and in 1983 Joe O'Neill initiated the monthly newsletter.

Michael Dickson, the then secretary of the IWG, took on the newsletter's production. Initially this took the form of a single sheet printed on both sides but by the early 1990s it was several pages long. In the spring of 1993 the Dublin Chapter's Garth May produced the first *Dublin Chapter Journal*. Within a year David Sweeney introduced the magazine and in 1995 the Dublin Chapter undertook the task of producing *The Journal* for the whole IWG membership. A year later the National Executive Committee took on the task appointing a *Journal* Editor to the Committee. Through the stewardship of Peter Mulvaney, Hanspeter Bodmer, Peter Lyons and now Rich Varney *The Journal* has become a professional 64-page, full-colour, quarterly magazine considered to be among the best of its kind.

The *Journal* echoes the workings of the IWG and devotes 50% of its space to reports from the all the Chapters around the country. This approach helps the Chapters to learn from what other Chapters are doing and also encourages them to improve their offerings to their own members.

During his time as Editor, Peter put out an appeal to try to get a full set of copies of the *Journal* from the beginning. Paddy O'Connor came forward with a full set, in a carrying case! This was given to the National Library of Ireland and it is kept up to date as each new issue of the magazine is added. A separate set was compiled from many sources and this travels with the post of the *Journal* Editor.

The 2012 Chapter Challenge demanded the teams turn their attention to creating intricate spinning wheels

Demonstrators at the 25th IWG seminar in 2008. The event set a high benchmark for future events

Seminars

The first woodturning seminar was held in Ireland in 1982, the year before the foundation of the Irish Woodturners' Guild. This event was organised by Liam O'Neill and others who had no idea how many, if any, woodturners would attend. This event was essentially a two-day upskilling course supported by Craft Supplies (UK) whose then instructor Phil Reardon taught basic skills while Ray Key demonstrated more advanced techniques.

In 1983, the first annual seminar organised by the newly formed IWG was held and hosted a great number of delegates due to the efforts of members. The seminars for 1984-1986 were held in Letterfrack, County Galway, and saw the introduction of prizes for the best pieces in a number of categories. This awarding of prizes for the best work at the seminar is still a major feature of IWG seminars.

The events are organised by the National Executive Committee and hosted by a local Chapter. The local Chapter does the research on the ground for suitable venues and submits a proposal to the National Executive Committee. The local Chapter also provides much of the equipment required and the stewarding during the event.

Until 2008 the demonstrations were held in a school, during the October half-term break, with a local hotel providing meals and accommodation. A feature of each of the early seminars was the inclusion of a well-known American woodturner plus at least one from the UK. By the mid-1990s the number of UK demonstrators at each seminar had increased and often a European turner was included. By 2000, American, European and UK demonstrators were a feature of each seminar. At this time the seminar was still a two-day event.

As 2008 approached – the year of the 25th Annual seminar – the National Executive Committee at the time wanted to do something special to mark the occasion. It was agreed that the anniversary seminar would be a three-day event; have as many as possible of the original demonstrators from the 1983 seminar; and be held under one roof. The 24th seminar had been hosted in Ballina, County Mayo, by the Craobh Eo Chapter and it gallantly agreed to host the 25th seminar having found a suitable hotel in Enniscrone only a few miles from Ballina. This seminar had almost double the usual number of demonstrators and was deemed to be a great success.

The years since have seen the 'all-under-one-roof' and the three-day format retained. The National Executive Committee is committed to constantly improving the seminar for the benefit of the delegates who come from all over Ireland, the UK, the USA and Europe. It is remarkable that hotels are willing to cope with the mess that woodturners make though the area around each lathe is covered with plastic sheeting.

The 2008 seminar saw the introduction of the annual Chapter Challenge. The

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